

Piracy is Green

NEWS

Researchers in Carnegie Mellon University, in a study sponsored by Microsoft and Intel have concluded that downloading MP3s from the internet has a considerably reduced carbon footprint over traditional approaches of music distribution. They considered purchasing CDs from stores, ordering music CDs online, after which they are delivered to homes, downloading files before burning them on CDs and just using the downloaded files and playing them on computers and PMPs without burning them on CDs. The cost of packaging, transportation, commutation and energy taken up to listen to the music were all factored in. While the study does not explicitly state that downloading illegal MP3s is more environmentally friendly than purchasing CDs from a retail outlet, it is a pretty safe assumption to make.

There are some other interesting conclusions of the study though. If you start feeling guilty about purchasing music from retail outlets because of the harm it causes to mother nature, you can compensate by walking to the retail store instead of driving. This puts the footprints of downloads and purchases at par. The original research paper can be downloaded at <http://snipurl.com/qtsji>.

tech art: ANSI art



Image Credit: Shaggy (of ICE)

ANSI art uses the same basic principles as ASCII art, but using the character set of IBM's Code Set 437. ANSI art had a huge advantage over ASCII art because of the inclusion of certain dingbats, glyphs and block characters and the ability to colour them. ANSI art was really popular in the first few years of the 1990s, and there were clans that created ANSI art for public distribution. Each block on an ANSI artwork was similar to a pixel, and this image is by Ice, one of the most popular ANSI groups on bulletin boards in the early days of the internet. A lot of ANSI artwork still flies around today, often unnoticed. Just open up those .nso files using an .nso viewer when you find one.

The First "Virus"

HISTORY

The earliest viruses to infect thousands of personal computers was the © Brain virus, a program that was not meant to be a virus at all. Three brothers in Pakistan, Amjad, Shahid and Basit Alvi had started up a computer firm in Pakistan in the early eighties. They first started by offering support to those who had purchased computers, as there was no such official mechanism in Pakistan at that time. Later on, they began to make software for some of their customers. They wrote a program for Doctors, and used an early form of DRM in the disks of their software. If the floppy was illegally replicated, the boot sector got corrupted, and a message flashed on the screen of the users. The message was a jovial call to contact the brothers (the phone numbers was included), to get a "vaccination" because of an "infection" (their customers were doctors remember?). Someone implemented the 3.5 KB file on a DOS disk, and the "virus" spread like wildfire, every time someone copied or traded an illegal version of a software. The Alvi brothers were bombarded by calls from all around the world, asking them to clear up the problem. Just when authorities were about to raise a fuss about the issue, they realised that the virus actually showed the scale of the rampant piracy - even in the early days of computing, and the fuss died down. However, this was not before Time magazine branded the virus as "Pakistani Flu" and published a none too flattering article about these "malicious hackers".



For those who came in late

Muddled by so many terms used in the mag? Here's your short guide to the tech lingo

RAID: RAID - Stands for redundant array of independent disks, is a system where hard disks are used in different configurations for a range of data saving approaches, optimised for speed, secure storage and backup.

Cloud: A central online location of data (documents, images, multimedia files etc), as well as any application or engine that allows users to interface with the data.

Beta: Early trial versions of games, operating systems, applications or hardware, given to a select group of testers, our given to the public for testing.

API: Application Programming Interfaces are layers of protocols between an application and an operating system, or a set of libraries. Usually released to coders for software development.